

An introduction to being trauma-aware

Clare Forero, Senior Practitioner, Strengths-based Practice Team
Sarah Merrills, Senior Practitioner, Strengths-based Practice Team

Aims of the session

- ✓ To provide a basic understanding of what trauma is, its prevalence and recognise how it can impact on us, people as individuals, groups and communities.
- ✓ To explore ways, we can respond that are supportive and prevent further harm by being trauma-aware.

Housekeeping

We kindly ask that during the session you;

- Keep your cameras on
- Keep your microphones muted unless you are talking
- Free yourself from distractions
- There will be a short comfort break approximately half-way through the session
- The presentation will be shared in the meeting chat after the session.
- Respect other peoples' opinions and perspectives
- Keep what is shared within this space confidential
- Due to the content of the session being around trauma, please be mindful of what you choose to share, think:
Professional, Personal, Private.
- Be mindful of your wellbeing as we go through the session and take a break if you need to

Session overview

The legislative context

What is trauma

What is trauma-aware practice

Why does it matter

What is the impact of trauma

What does trauma-aware practice look like

The legislative landscape

The “***Making the case for trauma informed strategy and legislation in England briefing paper***” reports on several key legislative acts that demonstrate the significant impact of legislation on addressing trauma which are:

- Care Act 2014
- Children Act 1989 and 2004
- Children and Social Work Act 2017
- Domestic Abuse Act 2021
- Employment Rights Act 1996
- Equality Act 2010
- Health and Safety at Work Act 1974
- Mental Health Act 2007

Updates to other legislation and guidance:

- Working Together to Safeguard Children (2023)
- The Children’s Social Care National Framework (2023)
- People at the Heart of Care: Adult Social Care Reform (2022)

The wider context

In the UK, Wales ([Trauma-Informed Wales](#)) and Scotland ([National Trauma Transformation Programme](#)) have made national-level progress to become fully trauma informed nations.

The Northern Ireland governments are implementing training in trauma-informed care for a wide variety of frontline workforces.

In England there are cities and counties that have become trauma-informed such as Plymouth, Lancashire, Sussex, Somerset and Derbyshire.

The Local Context

Nottingham and Nottinghamshire Trauma Informed Partnership

[Trauma informed Partnership](#)

[Trauma-Informed Training Providers and Resources](#)



What is Trauma?



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Working definition of trauma - GOV.UK

Trauma results from an event, series of events, or set of circumstances that is experienced by an individual as harmful or life threatening.

While unique to the individual, generally the experience of trauma can cause lasting adverse effects, limiting the ability to function and achieve mental, physical, social, emotional or spiritual well-being.

“Trauma is not what happens to you, but what happens inside you.”

(Gabor Mate, The Myth of Normal, 2002)

Trauma can arise from many places, so it is difficult to estimate how many people in Britain are living with its lasting effects.

What we do know is that at least 1 in 10 of us will have had four or more traumatic experiences as children.

(Adverse childhood experiences: What we know, what we don't know, and what should happen next
| Early Intervention Foundation)

Trauma is common in our communities, with some areas facing even higher levels – especially places with high levels of poverty, and communities with complex needs. (Public Health Needs Audit)

Many of us, our colleagues, and the children, adults and families we support will have also been affected by trauma, either in their personal lives or through the work they do.

We have a shared responsibility to look after each other with respect, kindness, and understanding. This work is about changing behaviours and through this changing the culture of how we work.

Adult Social Care and Health, and Children and Families Department Strengths-based Practice

Strengths-Based Approach

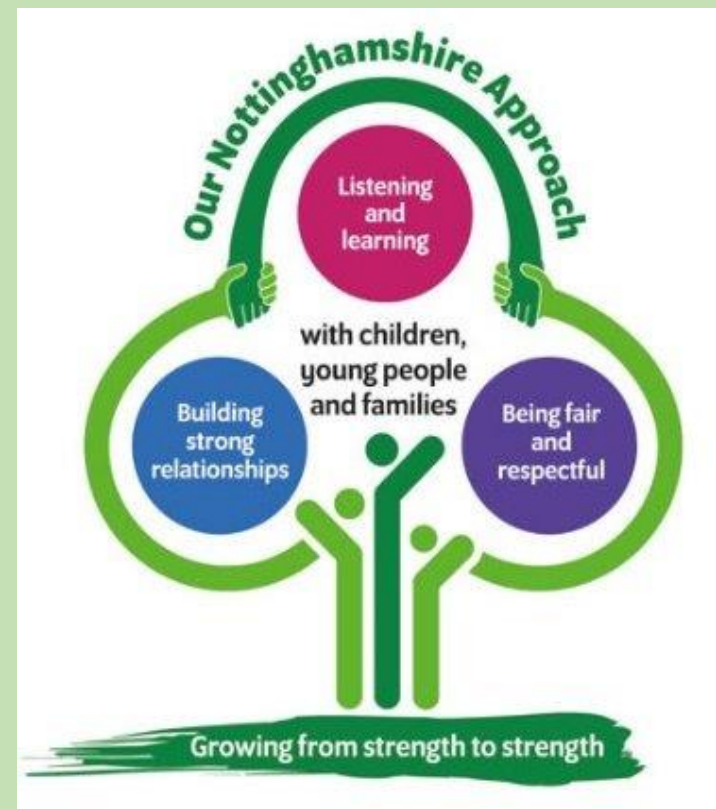
Asks the question 'what does a good life look like for you' rather than focus on someone's needs

Walking alongside people power sharing and social justice principles

Focusses on what's strong not what's wrong

What's possible and who cares – reflecting and improving

Reconnects people with their community building resilience



[Strengths-based Approaches in Adult Social Care | Nottinghamshire County Council Intranet](#)

[Our Nottinghamshire Strengths-Based Approach | Nottinghamshire County Council Intranet](#)

Our Nottinghamshire approach

The Nottinghamshire Strengths-based approach within both Adults' and Children's services provide a framework in which the six key principles of Trauma-informed Practice can be embedded:

1. **Safety** - I don't feel threatened
2. **Trust** – Colleagues do what they say they will
3. **Choice** - What are my options
4. **Collaboration** - We are in this together
5. **Empowerment** - I am taking control of my life
6. **Cultural consideration** - I am being seen and heard



The 4 phases of becoming a Trauma Informed Service/Organisation

Our starting point

Where we aspire to be

Phase	Definition
Trauma Aware	The organisation has a basic understanding of what trauma is, its prevalence and recognises how it can impact on people who use services and staff.
Trauma Sensitive	The organisation has begun to: explore the Trauma Informed principles in daily work; build consensus; consider the implications of embedding Trauma Informed practice; and is preparing for change.
Trauma Responsive	The organisation is readily responding to trauma, including support for both the people who use the service and staff, and has begun to change the culture to align with the Trauma Informed principles.
Trauma Informed	A Trauma Informed (TI) approach is the norm, accepted and embedded in the organisation so it no longer depends on a few 'champions', 'coaches' or 'leaders'. The organisation continues to work with partners (people with lived experience, communities, and multi-agencies) to strengthen and adapt its Trauma Informed approach. The programme or service has been rigorously evaluated and outcomes demonstrate the positive impact of changes made.



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What is being Trauma-Aware?

“Trauma aware is when we start to recognise trauma around us. We start to see the effects of trauma in those to whom we provide a public service, our colleagues, and people in our communities. Recognising trauma is the first step in working to keep people safe and helping them to create a safe and positive future.”

[The 4 Steps - Trauma Informed Lancashire](#)

Trauma-aware Practice

Trauma-aware practice is realising that trauma can affect individuals, groups and communities.

It aims to:

- Improve the accessibility and quality of services by creating culturally sensitive, safe services that people trust and want to use.
- Seeks to prepare practitioners to work in collaboration and partnership with people and empower them to make choices about their health and wellbeing.
- Recognises the signs, symptoms and widespread impact of trauma.

Trauma-aware practice acknowledges the need to see beyond an individual's presenting behaviours and to ask:

‘What happened to you?’ rather than ‘What is wrong with you?’

Behaviour is communication - Trauma might look like



Leicester.gov.uk

'Bad' Behaviour Iceberg



Lived experience



[Lads like us -Are we really that hard to reach ? – YouTube](#)

1minute and 2 seconds



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Being trauma-aware...

...Why does it matter?



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Why we need to be trauma aware

“Becoming more aware of trauma can help practitioners to spot the signs of trauma and improve service engagement and outcomes.”

([Home - Trauma Informed Lancashire](#))

Impacts of trauma on individuals

Studies carried out in England, Wales, and the USA consistently demonstrate that around 50% of the population has experienced at least one traumatic or stressful event in childhood. Without the right support, trauma can have negative, lasting effects on physical health, mental health, and social outcomes.

Vulnerability is multi-layered, below are examples of some of the impacts trauma-related vulnerability can have on an individual:

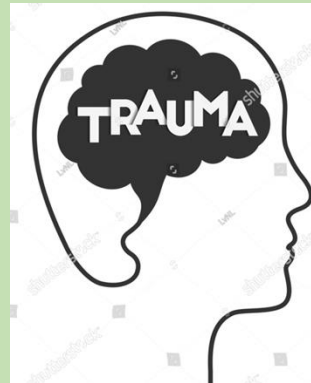
- disrupted nervous, hormonal, and immune development
- poor emotional, mental and physical health
- engaging in health harming behaviour
- being involved in violence
- more likely to have communication needs
- more likely to have lower educational attainment, and special educational needs (SEN)
- experiences of isolation and loneliness

Office for Health Improvement and Disparities.. Guidance: Vulnerabilities: applying All Our Health. Published 29 March 2022

[Vulnerabilities: applying All Our Health - GOV.UK](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/vulnerabilities-applying-all-our-health)

For people who've experienced trauma, moving into a safer environment doesn't automatically switch off the brain's survival response. They can remain stuck in 'survival mode' even when the danger has passed and "normal" everyday interactions can signal danger to their brain.

Trauma can shatter our core feelings of trust, safety, and predictability.



People can be developmentally 'stuck' in their brainstem, and very little information can get passed up to the higher parts of their brain beyond the primitive brain.

Whilst they remain here, they can struggle to

- form secure attachments
- manage their emotions or behaviour
- think, learn, or reflect



Their brain is simply trying to stay alive in a world that has been conditioned into seeing danger. This may make it difficult for individuals to trust others and access support. Their behaviours may be an attempt to maintain distance as they try to keep themselves safe.

Some of the survival behaviours we may see

Fight – shouting, explosive behaviours, restlessness, argumentative saying no, controlling

'I must prove I am right and dominate this interaction.'

Flight – running away, isolating, avoidant, backing away, not accessing support, anxious

'I need to get out of this interaction as soon as possible.'

Freeze – tense, silent, still, withdrawn, denial, numb, daydreaming, pounding heart, make self invisible, overwhelm

'I am overwhelmed, I don't know what to say or do.'

Fawn – (friend) people pleasing, passive behaviours, compliant, agreeable, overly helpful, no boundaries

'I must agree and be pleasant to avoid any conflict.'

Flop – physical and mental collapse, shutdown, play dead

'It's useless to try, I can't make a difference in this interaction.'

Personal reflection

Think about a challenging interaction you have had in a work or personal context

- Considering the survival responses, could your response, or the other person's response have been one of these?
- What is your default survival behaviour?



10 minute comfort break



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Impacts of trauma on groups and communities

The Lankelly Chase [Hard Edges](#) report suggests that 85% of people facing multiple disadvantage as adults experienced trauma as children ([Hard-Edges-Mapping-SMD-2015.pdf](#))

Individuals who have experienced trauma are more likely to:

- become teenage parents
- witness violence
- not be in education, employment or training
- live in poverty and experience developmental delays
- experience disproportional health needs leading to youth custody (mental health, alcohol, and learning disability (LD))
- experience issues with housing – poor respiratory and mental health
- be care experienced and become involved in offending

Office for Health Improvement and Disparities. Guidance: Vulnerabilities: applying All Our Health. Published 29 March 2022
[Vulnerabilities: applying All Our Health - GOV.UK](#)

What is Cultural Trauma?

Cultural trauma is a type of trauma that is shared by a group of people who have a shared experience of pain and suffering. It is a type of trauma that is passed down through generations and can be seen in the form of physical, emotional, and psychological scars. Examples of cultural trauma include the Holocaust and slavery. Cultural trauma can be triggered by events that happen to an individual, as well as by events that happen to a larger group of people. It can also be triggered by historical events that have left indelible marks on a culture or society.

Impacts of Cultural Trauma

Cultural trauma has been linked to many mental health struggles, such as depression, anxiety, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), and even addiction. People who experience cultural trauma may feel:

- disconnected from their culture and have difficulty forming bonds with others.
- overwhelmed by the burden of their shared experience and have difficulty trusting others.
- a sense of guilt and shame, and this can lead to feelings of self-loathing.

Additionally, people who experience cultural trauma may have difficulty managing their emotions and may find it difficult to regulate their moods.

[Cultural Trauma: How It Affects People and How to Cope — Purple Sky Counseling](#)

The impact of trauma-related vulnerability on service provision

'The cost of late intervention is estimated at £16.6 billion a year. While not all late intervention is avoidable, there are considerable resources being spent tackling issues that could have been dealt with sooner, and at less cost to the individual and to services. Some social determinants of health make people more vulnerable – addressing these factors should also reduce health inequalities more generally.

A lack of awareness about the impact of vulnerability can lead to social exclusion, a lack of support or onward referral and/or the potentials for re-traumatisation. There can be a link between the experience of trauma, sometimes from childhood, and the risk of a range of poor outcomes.'

Office for Health Improvement and Disparities. Guidance: Vulnerabilities: applying All Our Health. Published 29 March 2022
[Vulnerabilities: applying All Our Health - GOV.UK](#)

What does being trauma-aware look like?



Trauma-aware practice

Trauma often occurs in the context of relationships – and so can recovery.

Relationships are central to trauma-aware practice, as these provide the building blocks to support healing through safety, and trust.

Supportive, consistent, and respectful interactions help rebuild a sense of control and connection.

Practitioners can be trauma-aware in their practice by:

- Showing empathy and compassion
- Enabling collaboration
- Valuing each person's story without judgement
- Having clear boundaries which create predictable and empowering environments

[\(Trauma Informed Framework SHC\)](#)



Lived experience of receiving a trauma-aware response



[Lads like us -Are we really that hard to reach ? – YouTube](#)

1 minute 55 seconds

Using a trauma-aware approach is an important and powerful tool for creating a safe and supportive work environment for all we work with and for.

By understanding trauma and its impact, promoting cultural humility and creating opportunities for healing and growth, organisations can foster a workplace culture that is inclusive, respectful and productive.



One minute guide



Our Nottinghamshire Approach key strengths-based principles alongside trauma-informed principles

Date: August 2024
Version: 1

We have a strengths-based approach in Nottinghamshire and are striving to become more trauma-informed. We have detailed below the combined principles, with examples in practice.

Recognise the trauma which may have been or is being experienced by ourselves, each other, and the children, young people, and families we support. Understanding this brings compassion and empathy.

An example in practice is consideration that someone may need to build trust before accepting support.

Build **safety** for ourselves, each other, children, young people, and families.

An example in practice is creating safe environments for ourselves and others, and safe supportive relationships where we can build trust, reduce risks and encourage progress.

Resist re-traumatisation by looking at how our systems, structures, practices, and policies may cause further harm to ourselves, each other, our children, young people, and families.

An example in practice is how language can re-traumatise. It can change the way we think about ourselves and others. It is considering the importance of using strengths-based words. What we say and write can become part of a person's narrative.

Trust and be transparent with ourselves, each other, our children, young people, and families.

In practice this is setting clear boundaries, being clear on what is possible, what our needs are, what is realistic for us to achieve and what the consequences of not doing something would be for everyone involved.

Be **collaborative** by working with the person rather than doing 'to' or 'for'. See the human behind the behaviour and remember that people know their own lives and journeys better than anybody else.

An example in practice is to focus on people's strengths, capabilities, motivations, and resources. It is also to work with other services and communities to provide a holistic and sustainable support network.

Empower, give choice and control. Being a professional can sometimes make people who have experienced trauma feel even more powerless in relationships.

An example in practice is utilising lived experience as a way of giving people back their power. Listening to the voices of each other, our children, young people and families and use these to offer choices, and influence and shape our services.

Be **culturally considerate** and **fair and respectful** through inclusive practice that seeks to understand people within the context of their culture.

An example in practice is meeting people where they are at in their life's journey and recognising difference and diversity.

Key contacts

Name: Strengths-based practice team

Email: strengthsbasedpractice@nottscc.gov.uk

[one-minute-guide-key-strengths-based-and-trauma-informed-principles-v2-pdf.pdf](#)

Opening Doors: Trauma Informed Practice for the Workforce



[Opening Doors: Trauma Informed Practice for the Workforce on Vimeo](#) 8 minutes 41 seconds



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Small group discussion

breakout rooms

Do you already apply the principles of a trauma-aware approach in your work?

- If so, share what things you are doing to support this approach.
- Where are your spaces of influence?

Such as in team meetings, networking, in training etc...



Dr Karen Treisman

["Every interaction can be an intervention" video by Dr Karen Treisman – YouTube](#)

4 minutes 25 seconds



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“Every moment and interaction can be an intervention” (Treisman)

As a Trauma-Aware practitioner I will...

Respond with compassion, kindness and facilitating support has a genuine impact.

Be curious about behaviours and not make judgements.

Recognise that traumatic experiences may be common amongst people and colleagues.

Take time to build consistent, safe and trusting relationships.

Let individuals choose where to meet to create physical and psychological safety.

Support people to make their own decisions and write their own plans.

Show sensitivity to the cultural identities that are important to individuals.

Never turn people away, support connections. Introduce them to someone who can help and offer a sensitive handover.

Work with partner agencies to coordinate support, where people don't have to re-tell their stories.

Be curious about people's stories think “ what has happened to you” not “what is wrong with you”

Supporting connections

Reaching out/asking for support may have taken an individual a lot of courage and time, meaning if we don't handle their request sensitively, they may not reach out again for fear of their needs not being met a second time.

It can also lead to re-traumatising people as they are having to keep re-telling their story.

Do you know of any resources and/or services that are available to support staff, individuals and families who may have experienced trauma?

Helpful resources and support services to share

- [Age UK | Let's change how we age](#)
- [NCC wellbeing pages](#)
- [Local Mental Health Teams | Nottinghamshire Healthcare NHS Foundation Trust](#)
- [Help in a crisis | Nottinghamshire Healthcare NHS Foundation Trust](#)
- [Support for Young People in Nottingham - Base 51](#)
- [Contact Us | Notts Talking Therapies](#)
- [Trauma and Post-Traumatic Stress | NottAlone - Supporting Friends & Family](#)
- [We're Mind, the mental health charity | Mind](#)
- [Your Notts Directory](#)
- [Getting help for domestic violence and abuse - NHS](#)
- [Home - Women's Aid](#)
- [Samaritans | Every life lost to suicide is a tragedy | Here to listen](#)
- [Home - Victim Support](#)
- [Home - Kooth](#)
- [Trauma cards - Nottinghamshire Police](#)

Helpful resources and support services to share continued...

- [childline | Free counselling service for kids and young people | Childline](#)
- [Deaf-initely Women | Deaf Women in Derby, Derbyshire, Nottingham, Nottinghamshire, Stronger Together](#)
- [Improving children's and young peoples mental health – Place2Be](#)
- [Domestic abuse | Equation](#)
- [How PEGS Can Help | Pegs Support](#)
- [Change Grow Live | Charity | We can help you change your life](#)
- [Hetty's Charity | Support for Families Affected by Drug and Alcohol Misuse](#)
- [Harmless & The Tomorrow Project – Harmless](#)
- [Zero Suicide Alliance \(ZSA\) - suicide prevention and awareness UK](#)
- [Find trauma support groups in Nottingham](#)
- [SurvivorsUK | About us](#)

Helpful resources and support services to share continued...

- [UK Armed Forces and military veterans charity | Help For Heroes](#)
- [Home - Phenomenal Futures](#)
- [Zephyr's – Nurturing Support for bereaved families](#)
- [Home - Cruse Bereavement Support](#)
- [Helping Children & Young People Through Trauma | Children's Bereavement Centre](#)
- [Home - CASY](#)
- [Macmillan Cancer Support | The UK's leading cancer care charity](#)
- [Whatever the illness, we're with you to the end | Marie Curie](#)
- [Maggie's, Nottingham | Maggie's](#)
- [Transforming end of life care - John Eastwood Hospice](#)
- [Trauma informed practice - NHS Safeguarding](#)
- [Suicide prevention | Nottinghamshire County Council](#)

Helpful resources and support services to share continued...

- [CTRN UK- Childhood Trauma Network](#)
- [UK Trauma Council | Anna Freud](#)
- [Be U Support | Free Mental Health Service for Children and Young People](#)
- [HOME | Young Carers Notts](#)
- [Carers Hub | Nottingham City and Nottinghamshire County](#)



To summarise

By being trauma-aware and applying the six trauma-informed principles into our practice we can:

- Recognise the prevalence of trauma and how it can impact on ourselves, individuals, groups and communities.
- Avoid re-traumatisation by responding in ways that are supportive and prevent further harm.
- Establish safety and restore feelings of control.
- Provide clear and consistent boundaries.
- Offer persistent support and access to other networks.
- Help open doors, advocate and demonstrate inclusions and involvement.

A background image of a sunset or sunrise over a body of water, with a white rounded rectangle in the center containing text.

"I've learned that
people will forget
what you said,
people will forget
what you did, but
people will never
forget how you
made them feel."

Maya Angelou



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How do we keep trauma-aware conversations going?

Wellbeing activities

Supervision

Team meetings

Team-building activities

Regular reviews of policies and procedures

Support groups

Other...

Reflective questions to consider and take away

How will you further develop your trauma-aware practice?

How might you recognise trauma and its impact of on people?

How might you support someone displaying signs of trauma?



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- [Beacon House](#)
- [Trauma Informed Derbyshire - Derbyshire Mind](#)
- [Home - Trauma Informed Lancashire](#)
- [Home - Trauma Informed Plymouth Network](#)
- [Neurosequential Model: The 4 R's](#)
- [one-minute-guide-trauma-informed-principles.pdf](#)
- [Practice Development Unit \(PDU Nottingham\)](#)
- [Research and publications | Mind](#)
- [trauma-2020.pdf](#)
- [Working definition of trauma-informed practice - GOV.UK](#)
- [Supporting evidence-informed practice with children and families, young people and adults | Research in Practice](#)
- [Word of the month | Nottinghamshire County Council Intranet](#)
- [Care Act guidance on strengths-based approaches](#)
- Bessel van der Kolk- The Body Keeps the Score
- Bruce D. Perry and Oprah Winfrey – What Happened to you? Conversations on Trauma, Resilience and Healing

Further reading and resources



References

- [Cultural Trauma: How It Affects People and How to Cope — Purple Sky Counseling](#)
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- [Hard-Edges-Mapping-SMD-2015.pdf](#)
- [Home - Trauma Informed Lancashire](#)
- [Trauma informed practice | Leicestershire County Council Professional Services Portal](#)
- Maté, G. (2022) *The Myth of Normal: Trauma, Illness and Healing in a Toxic Culture*. London: Vermilion.
- [Mind-trauma-2020.pdf](#)
- NHS Education for Scotland. *Opening Doors Trauma Informed Practice for the workforce* (2018) www.nes.scot.nhs.uk
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- [Our Nottinghamshire Strengths-Based Approach | Nottinghamshire County Council Intranet](#)
- People at the Heart of Care: adult social care reform - GOV.UK
- Redding, A., Rushent, N., Irving, E. and Whittington, Z. (2024) *Making the Case for Trauma-Informed Strategy and Legislation in England*. [Briefing paper] December 2024
- Treisman, K. (2020) *Every interaction can be an intervention*. [YouTube video] Available at: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8pBkXbCP3Q4>
- [Trauma Informed Framework SHC](#)
- [Working definition of trauma-informed practice - GOV.UK](#)

Opportunities to be trauma-aware...

Previous Strengths-Based Practice Development Days - [watch the recordings](#)

Listening and Learning Week 2024 - [Listening and Learning Week 2024 | Nottinghamshire County Council Intranet \(nottsc.gov.uk\)](#)

Strengths-based
practice network

Strengths-based practice network
sign-up



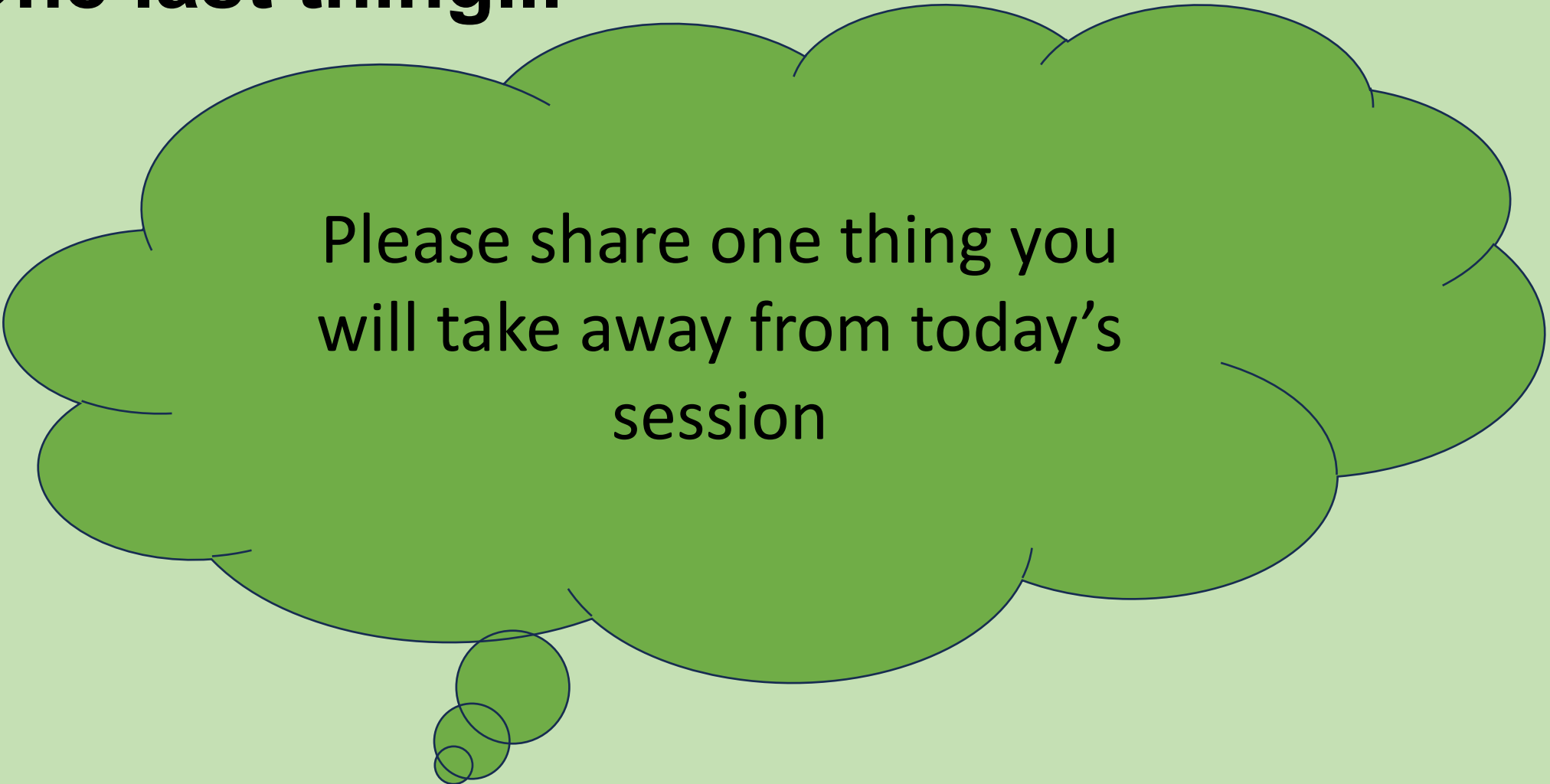
Children and Families Participation Network

Strengths-based practice hub intranet resources - [Our Nottinghamshire Strengths-Based Approach | Nottinghamshire County Council Intranet \(nottsc.gov.uk\)](#)

We invite you to be a strengths-based and trauma-aware activist!

Contact the Strengths-based Practice Team:
cfsstrengthsbasedpractice@nottsc.gov.uk

One last thing...



Please share one thing you
will take away from today's
session

Feedback and evaluation

Evaluation form

[Feedback Form for An introduction to being trauma-aware training – Fill in form](#)

Any questions?

Feedback Form for An introduction
to being trauma-aware training



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Taking care of yourself after an emotional session

-  Take a Breather - Step outside, stretch, or sit quietly for a few minutes.
-  Have a drink and Snack - Fuel your body to help reset your mind.
-  Write It Down - Jot a few thoughts or feelings to clear your head.
-  Talk to Someone - Share with a colleague or friend if you need to.
-  ♀ Do Something You Enjoy - Listen to music, take a walk, or do something that lifts you.
-  Be Kind to Yourself - It's okay to feel.